



NIGERIA

Capital city: Abuja

Area: 351,648 sq miles (910,770 sq km)

Population: 124,000,000

Official language: English

Major religions: Muslim 50%, Christian 40%, traditional beliefs 10%

Government: Military government

Currency: Naira

Adult literacy rate: 67%

Life expectancy: 45 years

People per doctor: 3,704

Televisions: 66 per 1,000 people

BENIN

Capital city: Porto-Novo

Area: 43,480 sq miles (112,620 sq km)

Population: 6,700,000

Official language: French

Major religions: Traditional beliefs 50%, Muslim 30%, Christian 20%

Government: Multiparty democracy

Currency: CFA franc

Adult literacy rate: 40%

Life expectancy: 53 years

People per doctor: 10,000

Televisions: 10 per 1,000 people

NIGERIA

NIGERIA IS HOME TO AN AMAZING mix of more than 250 different peoples. The largest groups are the Hausa-Fulani, in the north, the Yoruba in the west, and the Ibo in the east. Nigeria could be one of Africa's most successful economies. It has large reserves of oil, gas, and minerals, and abundant farmland. The population of 124 million is the largest of any African country, and one of the best educated. It has had a troubled history with a civil war in 1967 and a series of military coups. Today, Nigeria is struggling to pay off huge debts and to modernize its industry and agriculture.

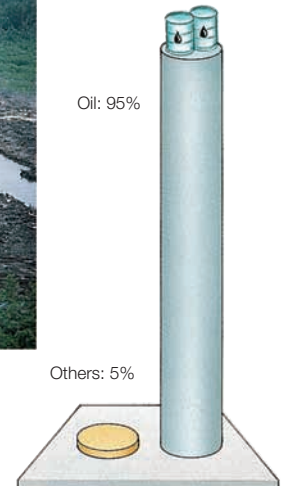
OIL

Oil was first produced in Nigeria in 1956, and within 20 years, the new industry dominated the economy. Today, it makes up about 95 percent of the country's exports. Nigerian oil is high quality with a low sulfur content, making it ideal as aircraft fuel. However, it is dangerous for a country to rely on just one product. When world oil prices fell in the 1980s, Nigeria suffered badly. Efforts are now being made to develop other products and lessen the country's dependence on oil.



The Niger Delta in the south of the country contains huge oil reserves, enough to last for at least another 25 years. Four huge refineries prepare the crude oil for export.

Main exports



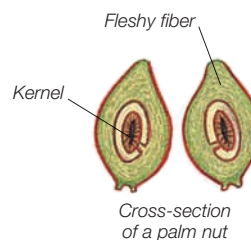
PLANTATIONS

In recent years huge plantations have been set up throughout Nigeria to produce crops in large quantities, mainly for export. Plantations make use of modern machinery to plant, grow, and process the crops, which include cotton, coffee, sugar, cocoa, and oil palms. Today, Nigeria is one of the world's largest producers of palm oil. Oil from the fleshy fiber of the palm nut is used in cooking oil, margarine, soap, candles, and paint.



Oil palm tree

Palm nuts grow in large bunches. When they are ripe, they are cut down and taken to factories where the oil is extracted.



Fleshy fiber

Kernel

Cross-section of a palm nut



Farmers clear and plow the land ready to plant crops.

SMALL FARMS

Most Nigerian farmers work on their own small farms. They use hoes, plows, and other simple tools to grow food crops such as cassava, rice, yams, and corn to feed their families. They also grow crops such as cocoa, oil palms, rubber, and peanuts to sell. These are known as cash crops. Despite the recent investment in plantations, most of Nigeria's cash crops are still grown on these small farms.



LAGOS

The city of Lagos is situated on a coastal island in the southwestern corner of Nigeria. The island was first settled in the 15th century by local Yoruba people. The town grew rapidly as a trading port used by European merchants and became the capital of independent Nigeria in 1960. In 1992, the capital was moved to Abuja, in central Nigeria, but Lagos is still the largest city.